

A Thin Veiled Night

The Reading Cut

writer: d.b.j

EXT. READING RAILROAD CUT / ABOVE TOPTON - NIGHT

Left boot hits wet rock fill and skids. Both palms catch the shale wall before the cut takes the last farm-road glow.

REED HOLCOMB (22) pounds downhill. Short iron pry locked in his right glove. TASHA VORN half a stride back. Abandoned Reading grade ahead: long red-shale throat, walls twice barn-high. Cold stone smell. Wet leaf smell. Metal taste like a bitten nail.

REED (V.O.)

My name is Reed Holcomb. I was twenty-two that night. We came down off the farm road above Topton because a thing in a faded trackwalker's coat stepped out of the tree line at the pull-off and started after us without a word. The cut was the only path that did not run us back into his hands.

TASHA

Gate at the far end. We close it and we are out the other side.

REED

If it still closes.

TASHA

It closed last October when we hauled the cooler through for the trail crew. Same pin. Same bar.

Rock fill shifts under every stride. Old ties go black in Tasha's phone beam, then disappear when she kills it. Along the left wall a thin ditch line of cold water keeps its own talk the length of the grade.

Behind them trackwalker boots step into the mouth they left open. The sound travels the stone throat even and sure, same nail, same hammer.

Reed tucks the pry under one arm and keeps moving.

TASHA

Reed. Your aunt's verse. Do it if you have to. Just do not stop for a sermon.

REED

I am not stopping.

CUT TO:

EXT. AUNT RAE'S BACK STEPS - DAY (SUMMER, SIX YEARS EARLIER)

Painted wood steps. AUNT RAE (50s) sits with a dish towel across her knees. Boy Reed (16) on the step below her, palms still raw from a river-trail night.

AUNT RAE

Three lines. Say them while your feet keep moving. No speech.

REED

What if my mouth goes empty.

AUNT RAE

Then you put the lines back in before the dark gets a vote.

She taps his knee once with two fingers.

AUNT RAE (CONT'D)

Jesus, shut what should be shut. Hold what I cannot hold. Keep my hands on the work.

Boy Reed repeats under his breath, already standing to leave.

CUT TO:

EXT. READING CUT / NARROW BULGE - NIGHT (PRESENT)

Reed's mouth carries the first line under breath. Boots on rock fill. Pry knocking his ribs. Walls throw the words back thin, then kill them on shale.

REED

(under his breath, still
running)

Jesus, shut what should be shut.
Hold what I cannot hold. Keep my
hands on the work.

Strip of sky between the walls. Behind them: canvas coat washed gray. Under the brim, a face that used to be a man's, bones shifting toward another shape. Mouth open on a wet noise. Arms hanging too far past the cuffs. No shout. The open gate behind him does the calling.

Tasha swears once, soft, the way she does when a weld goes bad on a job, and puts on speed.

The cut squeezes. Left wall humps over the ditch. Reed's shoulder scrapes wet stone. Pry rings a bolt head left in the rock from an old Reading brace. Cold shows. Sparks stay dark.

Trackwalker boots take the squeeze without slowing. Wet noise in his mouth thickens into a draw, open cut feeding him air he never earned.

TASHA

He is faster in here.

REED

Because the mouth is open. Aunt
Rae said a cut that stays open
after dark is a door with the
latch off.

TASHA

Your aunt said a lot of things.
Run.

Grade tips toward the downhill mouth. Rock fill piles thicker where washouts dumped stone into the old bed. Reed's left palm stings where the wall took skin on that first skid.

Halfway: drainage pipe under the grade. Ditch water shoots into a dark mouth the size of a washtub. Reed nearly drops a boot in. Catches himself on the pry jammed to the right wall. Tasha snags his jacket collar and hauls him clear without breaking her own pace.

TASHA
Watch the pipe.

REED
I see it now.

Trackwalker clears the pipe crossing clean. Coat brushes the rim and leaves a smear black in thin sky light.

Ahead: steel plate bolted into shale. READING COMPANY lettering still hangs on, rust chewing half the paint. Pale rectangle. Distance mark to the gate.

Tasha's phone light flicks once. Picks up the iron frame as a black rectangle on lighter dark. Dies again so they do not paint a target on their backs.

Loose spike across a tie. Reed kicks it clear. Spike rings once on stone. The cut swallows the sound.

Short work keeps going in a hard whisper that costs run-breath.

REED
Jesus, shut what should be shut.
Hold what I cannot hold. Keep my
hands on the work.

Trackwalker answers with that wet draw of breath, closer. Coat hits a shale jut and rips. Cloth noise. Wrong body noise under it, wet rope on a winch.

EXT. READING CUT / DOWNHILL GATE - NIGHT

Iron frame bolted into rock at the downhill mouth. Drop bar hangs vertical in its hinge, open. Socket empty. Linchpin

hangs on a short chain off the frame, left there by some trail kid after the last daylight pass.

Tasha hits the gate first. Both hands on the bar. Hauls.

Bar shifts two inches and dies. Rust. Cold. Iron bent from years of bikes slamming it. She hauls again. Bar groans and dies harder.

TASHA

Reed. Bar.

Reed arrives with the pry already rising. Behind them the trackwalker clears the squeeze. Cut throws his wet breath ahead like weather.

Reed sets the claw under the drop bar at the hinge plate and dumps his weight on the shaft. Iron complains. Bar jumps three more inches and hangs.

TASHA

Again.

They drive together. Her hands on the bar. His pry under the stuck place. Boots planted on wet rock fill. Bar swings over in a hard arc and falls toward the socket. Hits the lip of the iron cup and bounces. Will not seat. Hangs crooked while trackwalker boots chew the last fifty yards of grade in that even wrong meter.

REED

Pin.

TASHA

I know.

Tasha snatches the linchpin on its chain. Reed drives his left shoulder under the drop bar and forces the last inch into the socket while his right hand holds the pry wedged so the bar cannot spring. Socket takes the bar with a dull iron knock that climbs the rock walls. Tasha drives the linchpin at the hole in the bar end.

Pin hits frost and rust. Stops short of home.

THE TRACKWALKER hits the gate.

His hands, too long in the sleeves, clamp the iron frame from their side of the bars. His fingers kink wrong at the first knuckle. Coat smell: wet leaves, old creosote, sweet rot that does not belong on a railroad man. His face comes up against the gap above the drop bar. Under the brim his eyes hold too steady, a nail already bent and kept under the hammer.

TRACKWALKER

Open. The cut stays open. I need
the throat.

Tasha drives the linchpin again. Rust keeps the hole shut. Reed's shoulder shakes under the bar. Pry slips a half inch on wet iron.

Short work still sits in Reed's mouth. He shuts that mouth. Saves the breath for his shoulders.

Quiet hits the cut like a dropped plank.

Far side of the bars, the trackwalker yanks the frame. Drop bar shudders in the socket. With no short work in the air his strength climbs. Against Reed's shoulder the bar rises a finger's width. Tasha's boots slide on rock fill. Linchpin on its chain dances and misses the hole.

TASHA

Reed. Talk or shove. Pick one.

Reed shoves.

Both boots dig. Both hands leave the pry and take the bar itself, skin on cold iron. He drives the bar down into the socket with everything his shoulders own while Tasha lines the linchpin and hammers it with the heel of her glove. Pin metal jumps, catches the lip of the hole, then seats with a click that runs through Reed's teeth more than his ears.

Drop bar locks home in the socket with a final iron settle.

Trackwalker hauls the frame one last time. Whole gate shudders and holds. Rock bolts in the shale complain and stay. His face presses the gap above the bar. Wet noise in his mouth goes thin, then sour, then breaks into a cough that belongs to a man who walked this grade in a living year and cannot understand why the throat closed on him.

Reed puts the short work back into the air, quiet, hands still on the seated pin.

REED

Jesus, shut what should be shut.
Hold what I cannot hold. Keep my
hands on the work.

Trackwalker's pull dies. His long fingers slide off the iron. He steps back into the throat, locked bar between them, walls rising behind him. He stands on rock fill with the coat hanging wrong on ribs that learned a new cage. He eyes the seated pin the way a dog eyes a door that used to open.

TRACKWALKER

You left it open. I came because
it was open.

REED

We closed it.

TRACKWALKER

Closing costs. Your aunt knows.
Tell her the cut remembers the
Reading men who walked it sober
and the ones who did not.

He turns without another word and climbs the grade into the dark throat. Boots even. Coat torn. Wet draw of his breath fades under ditch water until the cut holds only stone, cold, and their own lungs.

EXT. GATE / TIE END - NIGHT

Tasha slides down the gate frame until she sits on a tie end, back to the iron. Peels her right glove. Heel where she hammered the pin: leather split. Blood shows dark when she flicks the phone for three seconds and kills it.

TASHA

You went quiet.

REED

Hands needed the air. It cost us.
He got stronger while I shut up.

TASHA

I saw that.
(flexes the split glove)
I also saw a dead railroad coat
try to pull a gate out of a rock
wall. I am not joining your aunt's
church because a linchpin seated.

REED

I know.

Night wind climbs from the fields below Topton. Neither of them fills it. Tasha's jaw works toward a box labeled adrenaline and bad light. Reed does not hand her that box. His hands stay on the linchpin, fingers check the seat, then leave it alone.

EXT. FARM ROAD SPUR / WALNUT TREE - NIGHT

They take the open grade downhill toward the spur where Tasha parked under a walnut. Behind them the cut mouth stays shut: drop bar home, pin seated, iron frame black on shale. No coat at the bars. Crickets start again at the field edge, ordinary and loud.

Reed wipes blood from his left palm onto his jeans. Keeps the pry under his arm. Will not leave iron to the dark.

At the truck the hood is cold. Dew beads the windshield. Tasha unlocks with a hand that shakes once and then stops, because she refuses to let fear finish a sentence. She drives them toward blacktop, heater low, split glove in her lap.

EXT. AUNT RAE'S PORCH - NIGHT

Kitchen light still burning. Aunt Rae reads the raw palms and the split glove and slides a dish towel under Reed's hands without asking for the long version first.

AUNT RAE

You closed it.

REED

Drop bar and pin. He was in the cut because we left the mouth open. He needed the throat. While I shut up to shove, he got stronger. When the pin seated and I put the short work back, he could not finish the pull.

Rae pours coffee that sat too long and sets the mug in reach. Turns his hands palm up. Clicks her tongue at shale grit still in the scrapes.

AUNT RAE

A cut is a throat. A throat with the latch off after dark is an invitation. Prayer is hands on the latch as much as words in the air. Next time you leave my gate open after a raccoon hunt, you shut it before you climb back to the farm road.

Tasha stands at the porch rail, jacket still zipped. One hard shake of the head. Done talking for the night.

TASHA

I'll grant the stop at the gate. I will not grant a Person on the other end of your aunt's three lines before I have a bandage and a beer. Reed, text me when your hands are cleaned up. I need a new glove and a story for the shop that does not mention trackwalkers in abandoned cuts.

She leaves. Screen door slaps. Aunt Rae rinses grit from Reed's palms under cold water and checks the linchpin

scrape across his thumb under porch light. She does not ask him to preach what happened. Hands him the towel. Tells him to come back at first light, walk the cut, and check the pin still sits true.

CUT TO:

INT. DINER ON MAIN / TOPTON - DAY (FOUR YEARS LATER)

REED (26) across from Tasha. Coffee. Trays. Tasha talks with her hands. She will grant the gate stop. A Person behind Aunt Rae's three lines stays off the table.

REED (V.O.)

I am twenty-six now. I still drive the farm road above Tipton when the light is low. The Reading cut still holds its red shale walls and its ditch and its iron gate at the downhill mouth. The borough painted the frame once and the paint peeled. Hikers leave the bar open in daylight and mostly remember to drop it before they go home. Tasha still sits across from me at the diner on Main and argues that prayer is a noise useful people make when a pin sticks. She will grant the stop at the gate. She will not grant a Person who answers three short lines while your shoulder is under a bar.

INT. REED'S TRUCK / GLOVE BOX - DAY

Reed opens the glove box. A spare linchpin rests on papers and a folded map, cut from the same stock as the one on the chain.

REED (V.O.)

I keep a spare linchpin in the glove box of my truck, cut from the same stock as the chain pin, in case the trail kids lose the original again. On nights when the

wind climbs the grade smelling of
wet stone and leaf rot, I check
that the drop bar still falls true
the way some people check a spare
tire. I do not open the cut after
dark for a dare. I do not preach
the gate at Tasha. When a mouth
that should be shut is hanging
open and a wrong walker is already
in the throat, my boots already
know the grade, and my hands take
the bar while my mouth takes the
short work Aunt Rae taught me on
the back steps.

EXT. READING CUT / DOWNHILL GATE - PRE-DAWN (MEMORY / CODA)

Iron frame. Drop bar. Linchpin on its chain. Wet rock fill.
Wrong boots somewhere up the throat. Hands already
deciding.

REED (V.O.)

If you ever run the abandoned
Reading grade above Tipton after
the light fails and hear boots
that hit ballast wrong behind you,
shut the downhill gate with your
hands before you make a speech in
the cut. The veil along that old
rock throat thins in the cold
hour. The pin still fits the hole.

FADE OUT.